

Arthritis and Alcohol – What You Need to Know

Can you drink alcohol with arthritis? UK guide to safe limits, medication interactions with methotrexate and NSAIDs, and how alcohol affects inflammation.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-22 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Alcohol and arthritis is a topic that causes confusion. Can you still enjoy a drink? Does alcohol make arthritis worse? And what about interactions with your medication? Here's what the evidence says.

How Alcohol Affects Arthritis

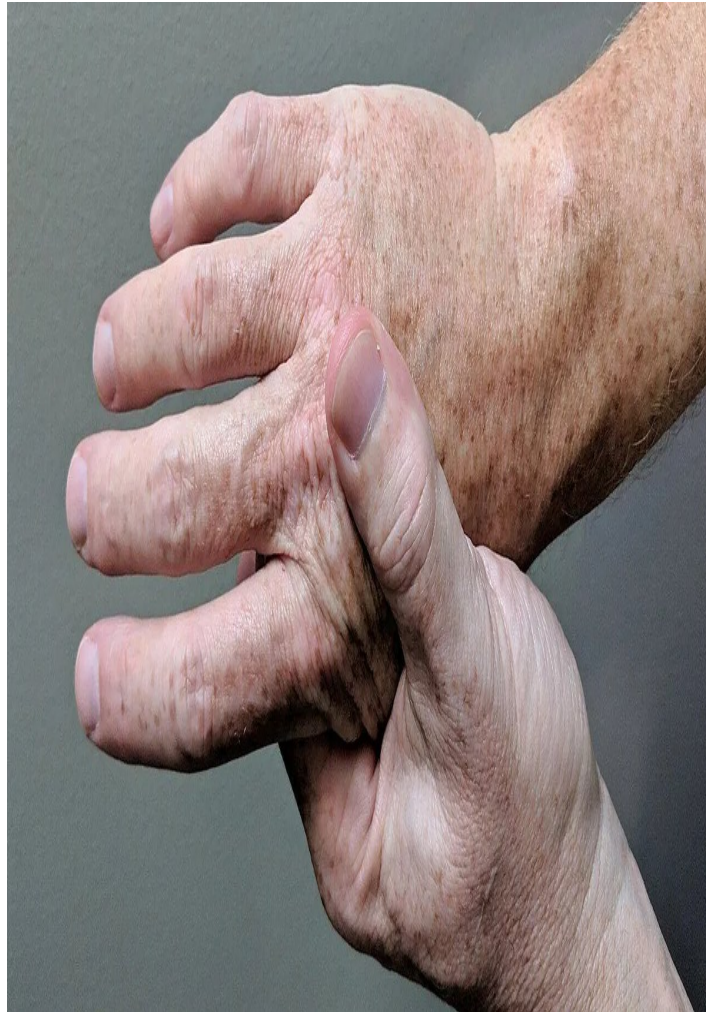
Potential Benefits (in Moderation)

Some studies suggest that moderate alcohol consumption may slightly reduce the risk of developing rheumatoid arthritis, possibly through anti-inflammatory effects. However, this doesn't mean alcohol is recommended as a health measure.

Potential Harms

- Inflammation — heavy drinking increases systemic inflammation
 - Weight gain — alcohol is calorie-dense, contributing to weight that stresses joints
 - Gout — alcohol (especially beer and spirits) is a major trigger for gout attacks
 - Sleep disruption — alcohol impairs sleep quality, worsening fatigue and pain
 - Bone health — heavy drinking reduces bone density, increasing fracture risk
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Medication Interactions



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Methotrexate

This is the most important interaction. Methotrexate and alcohol are both processed by the liver. Combining them increases the risk of liver damage. Current UK guidance from the BSR (British Society for Rheumatology) advises:

- Stay within NHS guidelines (14 units per week maximum)
- Some rheumatologists recommend lower limits or complete abstinence
- Discuss your individual risk with your rheumatologist
- Regular liver blood tests are essential while on methotrexate

NSAIDs (Ibuprofen, Naproxen)

Alcohol combined with NSAIDs increases the risk of stomach bleeding and ulcers. If you take regular NSAIDs, limit alcohol carefully.

Steroids (Prednisolone)

Both steroids and alcohol can irritate the stomach lining. Combining them increases ulcer risk.

UK Alcohol Guidelines

The NHS recommends no more than **14 units per week**, spread across 3 or more days. For context:

- 1 pint of beer/cider = 2-3 units
 - 1 glass of wine (175ml) = 2 units
 - 1 single spirit (25ml) = 1 unit
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Practical Tips



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- Have several alcohol-free days per week
- Choose lower-strength drinks when you do drink
- Alternate alcoholic drinks with water
- If you have gout, avoid beer entirely and limit all alcohol
- Be honest with your rheumatologist about your alcohol consumption

Everyone's situation is different. Discuss alcohol with your rheumatologist, especially if you take methotrexate or other liver-processed medications.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and alcohol – what you need to know?

Short answer: Moderate alcohol consumption may slightly reduce rheumatoid arthritis risk but can also worsen inflammation, gout, and sleep. Alcohol interacts with many arthritis medications: combining it with methotrexate increases liver damage risk, and with NSAIDs or steroids, it raises stomach ulcer risk. The NHS recommends no more than 14 units per week. Discuss alcohol intake with your rheumatologist.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk